The instability of negative-mass Schwarzschild is a point-mass effect:

Exact thresholds for finite stars and a radially stable negative-mass boson star

Nathan Moinvaziri*
Independent researcher

October 2026

Abstract

Negative-mass Schwarzschild spacetime is linearly unstable: Gleiser and Dotti exhibited, for every multipole $\ell \geq 2$, an even-parity mode growing as $e^{\gamma t}$ with $\gamma = (\ell-1)\ell(\ell+1)(\ell+2)/(12|M|)$, and gave numerical evidence that it is the only one. It has been suggested that the instability does not depend on the singularity and would survive in a regular negative-mass star. We prove, for every $\ell \geq 2$, that the Dotti–Gleiser operator has exactly one negative eigenvalue. The proof uses the zero-energy partner solution $\phi_0 = 1/\psi_0$ implicit in their intertwining construction, through a ground-state identity and Glazman's lemma. The same identity yields an exact count of unstable modes for the exterior of a star of areal radius R whose interior imposes a Robin condition $\hat{\Psi}' = \kappa\hat{\Psi}$: $\#\{\gamma > 0\} = [\, R < r_s \,] + [\, \kappa < \kappa_c(R) \,]$, with $r_s = 6|M|/[(\ell+2)(\ell-1)]$ and κ_c in closed form. Consequently the vacuum exterior of any star with $R \geq r_*(\ell)$ ($r_* = 2.279|M|$ for $\ell = 2$) and a non-energy-injecting surface condition ($\kappa \geq 0$) supports no unstable even-parity mode, and the ℓ^4 growth of the point mass is capped by any finite radius. We then study a concrete regular negative-mass object, a sextic boson star whose stress tensor enters Einstein's equations with a minus sign. We derive its radial perturbation equations, verify them symbolically, and find the configuration used in a recent full numerical-relativity study to be radially stable; the family loses stability exactly where the Noether charge is extremal. Because the first law becomes $\mathrm{d}M = -\omega\,\mathrm{d}N$, the turning-point criterion holds in N but reverses sign when written in M. Accurate spherically symmetric nonlinear evolutions confirm both the stationarity of the stable stars to $t = 1500$ and the predicted growth rates of unstable ones. For $\ell = 2, 3$ polar and all-ℓ axial perturbations we find no unstable mode, and the effective surface condition the star supplies stays above κ_c, so the point-mass instability is not triggered.

1 Introduction

Bondi's 1957 analysis [1] showed that general relativity contains no logical obstruction to negative mass, provided inertial, passive and active mass share a sign, and that a pair of equal and opposite masses self-accelerates (the "runaway"). Two questions have dominated the subsequent discussion: whether negative mass is dynamically stable, and whether the runaway is physical. The second was recently addressed by full $3+1$ evolutions of a canonical boson star paired with a "phantom" boson star of negative ADM mass [3]. Here we address the first.

For the vacuum point mass the answer is known. Gibbons, Hartnoll and Ishibashi [4] proved stability of the odd-parity sector and, for a range of boundary conditions at the naked singularity,

*nathan@nathanm.com

of the even sector. Gleiser and Dotti [5] then found exact, smooth, exponentially growing even-parity solutions and showed that the stability argument of Ref. [4] relies on a perturbation that is not continuous at an interior radius where the Zerilli variable is singular. Dotti and Gleiser [6] removed that "kinematic" singularity with an intertwining operator, obtained a regular operator $\hat{H}$ with a unique self-adjoint extension, and showed that the unstable mode is excited by generic data supported away from the singularity. Cardoso and Cavaglià [7] identified the modes as algebraically special. Whether the unstable mode is the only one was left as numerical evidence [6].

What a regular negative-mass source does to this instability has not been computed. In a recent review Dotti suggests that replacing the singularity by a small negative-mass distribution would leave the potential largely unchanged, so that "an unstable mode could be found anyway", and that "the singularity plays no role in the instability" [8]. Regular negative-mass configurations exist—perfect-fluid bubbles in de Sitter [9], scalar-field stars [3]—but stability analyses have been radial and restricted to special matter models [10, 11].

This paper makes three contributions.

1. We prove that $\hat{H}$ has exactly one negative eigenvalue for every $\ell \geq 2$ (Theorem 1), turning the numerical observation of Ref. [6] into a theorem.

2. For the exterior of a star of radius R with a Robin interface condition, we give an exact count of unstable modes for every ℓ (Theorem 2). The instability is a property of the region $r \lesssim 10|M|/\ell^2$: a star larger than $r_*(\ell)$ hides it unless its surface condition injects energy, and any finite star caps the growth rate. This quantifies, and for dilute stars contradicts, the expectation of Ref. [8].

3. We give the first linear stability analysis of a negative-ADM-mass boson star [3]. It is radially stable on the branch used in numerical relativity, with stability lost exactly at the extremum of the Noether charge, and we find no unstable $\ell = 2, 3$ polar or axial mode; the effective interface condition its interior supplies lies above κ_c.

Units $G = c = 1$. Sections 2–4 use $|M| = 1$; Sec. 5 uses the scalar mass $m = 1$. All computations are reproducible from the accompanying repository.

2 The intertwined Zerilli operator

Write the negative-mass Schwarzschild metric as $\mathrm{d}s^2 = -f\mathrm{d}t^2 + f^{-1}\mathrm{d}r^2 + r^2\mathrm{d}\Omega^2$ with $f = 1 - 2M/r = 1 + 2/r$ ($M = -1$), and the tortoise coordinate $x = r - 2\ln(1 + r/2)$, so $x \in (0, \infty)$ with $x \simeq r^2/4$ at the singularity. Even-parity perturbations with multipole $\ell \geq 2$ reduce to Zerilli's equation [13] $\partial_t^2 \Psi_Z + H_Z \Psi_Z = 0$, $H_Z = -\partial_x^2 + V_Z$. Let

$$c = (\ell + 2)(\ell - 1), \qquad k = \frac{(\ell - 1)\ell(\ell + 1)(\ell + 2)}{6} = \frac{c(c + 2)}{6}, \qquad r_s = \frac{6}{c}. \tag{1}$$

For $M < 0$ the potential V_Z has a double pole at r_s, which lies in the physical domain; it is "kinematic" because Ψ_Z itself has a simple pole there for smooth metric perturbations [5].

Dotti and Gleiser [6] use the static solution $\psi_0 = \chi(r)/(cr - 6)$ of $H_Z \psi_0 = 0$, where χ is the polynomial of degree $\ell + 2$ in their Eq. (55), and define $g = \psi_0'/\psi_0$ ($' = \mathrm{d}/\mathrm{d}x$),

$$A = \partial_x + g, \qquad H_Z = AA^*, \qquad \hat{H} = A^*A = -\partial_x^2 + \hat{V}, \qquad \hat{V} = g^2 - g'. \tag{2}$$

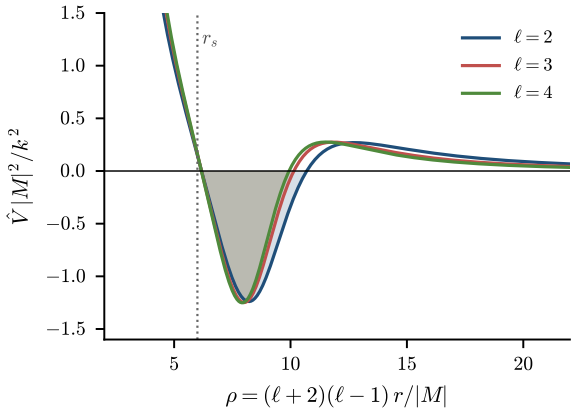


Figure 1: The regularised potential $\hat{V}$ for $\ell = 2, 3, 4$, in the scaled radius $\rho = cr/|M|$. Shaded: $\hat{V} < 0$, which occurs only on a shell just beyond r_s ($\rho = 6$). With radius scaled by $c = (\ell+2)(\ell-1)$ and the potential by the eigenvalue scale k^2, the curves nearly coincide.

$\hat{V}$ is regular, $\hat{H}A^* = A^* H_Z$, and $\hat{\Psi} = A^* \Psi_Z$ is smooth for smooth metric perturbations. The zero-energy partner of this factorisation,

$$\phi_0 = \frac{1}{\psi_0} = \frac{cr-6}{\chi(r)}, \qquad A\phi_0 = 0, \qquad \hat{H}\phi_0 = 0, \tag{3}$$

appears in Ref. [6] as the state "missing in the spectrum" of the supersymmetric partner. It is the object on which everything below rests. Figure 1 shows $\hat{V}$: it is negative only on a thin shell just outside r_s, and when lengths are scaled by c and energies by k^2 the shell is nearly independent of ℓ.

Lemma 1 (properties of χ, ϕ_0, $\hat{V}$; all $\ell \geq 2$)**.**

1. $\chi = \sum_{n=1}^{\ell+2} c_n r^n$ *with* $c_1 = \frac{3}{2}$, $c_2 = 0$, $c_3 = -K/32$, $c_4 = K/96$ *(*$K = 6k$*),* $c_n \geq 0$ *for* $n \geq 4$ *and* $c_{\ell+2} > 0$*;* ψ_0 *solves the static Zerilli equation identically in* ℓ*; and* $\chi > 0$ *on* $r > 0$*.*

2. *At* r_s *the* χ*-equation has Frobenius exponents* 0 *and* 3*, forcing* $\chi''(r_s) = 0$*; hence* $\hat{V}$ *is real-analytic on* $(0, \infty)$*.*

3. $r^4\hat{V} = 12 + O(r)$ *as* $r \to 0$ *(exponents* $x^{3/2}$*,* $x^{-1/2}$*), and* $\hat{V} \simeq (\ell+1)(\ell+2)/r^2$ *as* $r \to \infty$*.* $\hat{H}$ *is limit point at both ends, hence essentially self-adjoint on* $C_c^\infty(0, \infty)$*.*

4. ϕ_0 *is the non-admissible branch* $\propto x^{-1/2}$ *at* 0*, decays as* $r^{-(\ell+1)}$ *at infinity, and has exactly one zero, at* r_s*, which is simple.*

Sketch. (1) The closed form $c_n = (n-2)\big((n-4)\ell(\ell+1) + n - 1\big)(\ell - n + 3)_{2n-4}/\big(2^n(n-1)!^2\big)$ turns the static equation into a three-term recurrence, which becomes a polynomial identity in (ℓ, n) after dividing by a Pochhammer factor; it is verified symbolically. Positivity follows Ref. [6], Eqs. (57)–(59): dropping the non-negative terms $n \geq 6$ leaves a quartic whose unique positive critical value is $4(K-18)(Ks - 18(K-16))/[(\ell-2)(\ell+3)(\ell^2+\ell+4)]^3$, $s = \sqrt{6(K-18)}$, which is positive because $(Ks)^2 - (18(K-16))^2 = 6(K-24)^3 > 0$ for $\ell \geq 3$; $\ell = 2$ is checked directly. (2)–(4) are local expansions, verified symbolically in ℓ; limit point at 0 holds because $x^{-1/2} \notin L^2$, and the Weyl alternative gives essential self-adjointness [15, 16]. □

3 Exactly one unstable mode

The key tool is the ground-state identity: if $\hat{V} = \phi_0''/\phi_0$ and $u = \phi_0 h$, then

$$u'^2 + \hat{V}u^2 = \phi_0^2 h'^2 + \big(\phi_0\phi_0' h^2\big)'. \tag{4}$$

Theorem 1. *For every $\ell \geq 2$, $\hat{H}$ has exactly one negative eigenvalue. It is simple and equals $-(k/2)^2$, so the unique unstable even-parity mode of negative-mass Schwarzschild grows at the Gleiser–Dotti rate $\gamma = k/(2|M|)$. Zero is not an eigenvalue.*

Proof. At most one. By Glazman's lemma [17], the number of negative eigenvalues equals the largest dimension of a subspace of a form core on which $q[u] = \langle u, \hat{H}u\rangle$ is negative definite. Take the core $C_c^\infty(0,\infty)$ and suppose such a subspace F has $\dim F \geq 2$. Choose $u \in F \setminus \{0\}$ with $u(x_s) = 0$, $x_s = x(r_s)$. Since ϕ_0 is analytic with a simple zero at x_s, $h = u/\phi_0$ is smooth, and integrating (4) over the compact support of u gives $q[u] = \int \phi_0^2 h'^2 \,\mathrm{d}x \geq 0$, a contradiction.

At least one. The function $\hat{\Psi} = A^*\Psi_{\mathrm{DG}}$, with $\Psi_{\mathrm{DG}} = r(r+2)^k e^{-kr/2}/(cr-6)$, satisfies $\hat{H}\hat{\Psi} = -(k/2)^2\hat{\Psi}$ identically in ℓ, is $O(r^3)$ at 0, regular at r_s, and decays exponentially; so it is an eigenfunction. Independently of this explicit mode, $w = \phi_0 \mathbf{1}_{x>x_s}$ lies in the form domain with $q[w] = 0$ by (4); if $\hat{H} \geq 0$, w would be a minimiser and hence a weak, therefore C^1, solution of $\hat{H}w = 0$, contradicting the kink at x_s.

No zero mode. The zero-energy solution admissible at $x = 0$ is

$$v = \phi_0 F, \qquad F(r) = \text{f.p.}\int_0^r \psi_0^2 \,\frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\mathrm{d}r}\,\mathrm{d}r;$$

it grows as $r^{\ell+2}$ and is not in L^2. □

Remark 1. v has exactly one zero for every ℓ (F is positive on $(0, r_s)$ and increases from $-\infty$ to $+\infty$ on (r_s, ∞)), as renormalised oscillation theory [18] requires. The proof does not use oscillation theory at the continuum edge. Numerically, Chebyshev discretisations with $\hat{\Psi} = r^3 u$ reproduce $E_0 = -(k/2)^2$ to $\leq 3 \times 10^{-13}$ for $\ell \leq 8$ and find no second bound state in 140 resolution and domain variations.

4 Finite stars: an exact count

Model the exterior of a star of areal radius R by $\hat{H}_{R,\kappa}$ on $L^2(x_R, \infty)$ with the Robin condition $\hat{\Psi}'(x_R) = \kappa\hat{\Psi}(x_R)$; $\kappa = +\infty$ denotes Dirichlet. The interior matter determines κ, which in general depends on frequency and ℓ; here it is a free parameter. Define

$$\kappa_c(R) = \frac{\mathrm{d}\ln\phi_0}{\mathrm{d}x}\Big|_R = \Big(1 + \frac{2}{R}\Big)\frac{\mathcal{N}(R)}{(cR-6)\chi(R)}, \qquad \mathcal{N} = c\chi - (cr-6)\chi'. \tag{5}$$

Theorem 2. *For every $\ell \geq 2$ and $R \neq r_s$, the number of negative eigenvalues of $\hat{H}_{R,\kappa}$ is*

$$[\,R < r_s\,] + [\,\kappa < \kappa_c(R)\,], \tag{6}$$

with Dirichlet counted as $\kappa = +\infty$. At $\kappa = \kappa_c$, ϕ_0 is a zero-energy eigenfunction.

Proof. For u in the core, (4) gives $q[u] = \int \phi_0^2 h'^2 \,\mathrm{d}x + (\kappa - \kappa_c)u(x_R)^2$ provided $u(x_s) = 0$ when $R < r_s$. Imposing $u(x_s) = 0$ (if $R < r_s$) and $u(x_R) = 0$ (if $\kappa < \kappa_c$) costs at most $[\,R < r_s\,] + [\,\kappa < \kappa_c\,]$ linear conditions and leaves $q \geq 0$; Glazman's lemma gives the upper bound. For the lower

ℓ	r_s	r_*	$r_{\rm neg}$	$\gamma_{\rm DG} = k/2$	$\lvert M\rvert/r_*$
2	1.5000	2.2788	2.6741	2	0.439
3	0.6000	0.8789	1.0143	10	1.14
4	0.3333	0.4814	0.5519	30	2.08
5	0.2143	0.3073	0.3512	70	3.25

Table 1: Thresholds in units of $|M|$. r_s: Dirichlet threshold; r_*: Neumann and $\kappa \geq 0$ threshold; $r_{\rm neg} = \sup\{r : \hat{V} < 0\}$. Since r_* decreases with ℓ (checked for $\ell \leq 80$), a star with $|M|/R < 0.439$ and $\kappa \geq 0$ has no unstable even-parity mode for any ℓ. At large ℓ, $r_* \approx 8.486/c$ and $r_{\rm neg} \approx 9.636/c$ (derived from the $\ell \to \infty$ limit of $c\,\chi(\rho/c)$, a modified-Bessel closed form; convergence of the roots is not proven).

bound use $w_1 = \phi_0 \mathbf{1}_{[x_R, x_s]}$ and $w_2 = \phi_0 \mathbf{1}_{[x_s,\infty)}$ (or ϕ_0 itself if $R > r_s$), for which $q[aw_1 + bw_2] = a^2\phi_0(x_R)^2(\kappa - \kappa_c)$ and $q[w_2] = 0$. If the negative spectral subspace were smaller, some combination orthogonal to it would have $q = 0$, hence be a weak zero-energy solution satisfying the boundary condition; the kink of w_2, or $\kappa \neq \kappa_c$, excludes this. □

Corollary 1 (thresholds, all ℓ)**.** *$\mathcal{N} > 0$ on $[0, r_s]$ and has exactly one root $r_* > r_s$. Hence $\kappa_c < 0$ on $(0, r_s)$, $\kappa_c \to \mp\infty$ at $r_s^{\mp}$, $\kappa_c > 0$ on (r_s, r_*) and $\kappa_c < 0$ on (r_*, ∞). In particular: Dirichlet is unstable iff $R < r_s$; Neumann is unstable iff $R < r_*$; every $\kappa \geq 0$ is stable iff $R \geq r_*$.*

The first claim follows from a telescoping lower bound on $[0, r_s]$; uniqueness of r_* from Descartes' rule applied to $\mathcal{N}(r_s + t)$, whose coefficients have one sign change because $\chi''(r_s) = 0$ and $\chi^{(m)}(r_s) > 0$ for $m \geq 4$. Table 1 lists the thresholds and Fig. 2 the critical surface condition. Asymptotically,

$$\kappa_c = -\frac{\ell+1}{R} - \frac{\ell^4 + 3\ell^3 + 4\ell^2 + 4}{\ell(\ell-1)(\ell+2)}\frac{1}{R^2} + O(R^{-3}) \qquad (R \to \infty), \tag{7}$$

$$\kappa_c\, x_R = -\frac{1}{2} - \frac{(\ell^2 + \ell - 1)R}{12} + O(R^2) \qquad (R \to 0). \tag{8}$$

For large R an instability therefore requires a surface condition softer than the static vacuum tail $\phi_0 \propto r^{-(\ell+1)}$ by an $O(1)$ factor on the scale $1/R$. As $R \to 0$ every condition with $\kappa x_R > -\frac{1}{2}$ (including Dirichlet and Neumann) reproduces the Dotti–Gleiser eigenvalue, with error scaling roughly as R^3–R^4, so the self-adjoint extension of Ref. [6] is the limit of a regular cutoff; compare the scalar-wave analysis of Ref. [14].

Growth-rate cap. For the point mass the growth rate $k/2 \sim \ell^4/12$ is unbounded in ℓ. For a star: with $\kappa \geq 0$ only ℓ with $R < r_*(\ell)$, roughly $\ell \lesssim 3/\sqrt{R}$, are unstable; with a fixed $\kappa < 0$, every ℓ with $r_{\rm neg}(\ell) < R$ has $\hat{V} \geq 0$ outside the star and growth $\leq |\kappa|$. Either way $\sup_\ell \gamma < \infty$ (Fig. 2, right; a 1000-case numerical scan agrees with Theorem 2). The unbounded growth belongs to the singularity.

5 A regular negative-mass star

Theorem 2 reduces the even-parity stability of any star with $R > r_*$ to the sign of the effective κ its interior supplies, together with the stability of the matter itself. We now examine the matter for a concrete model.

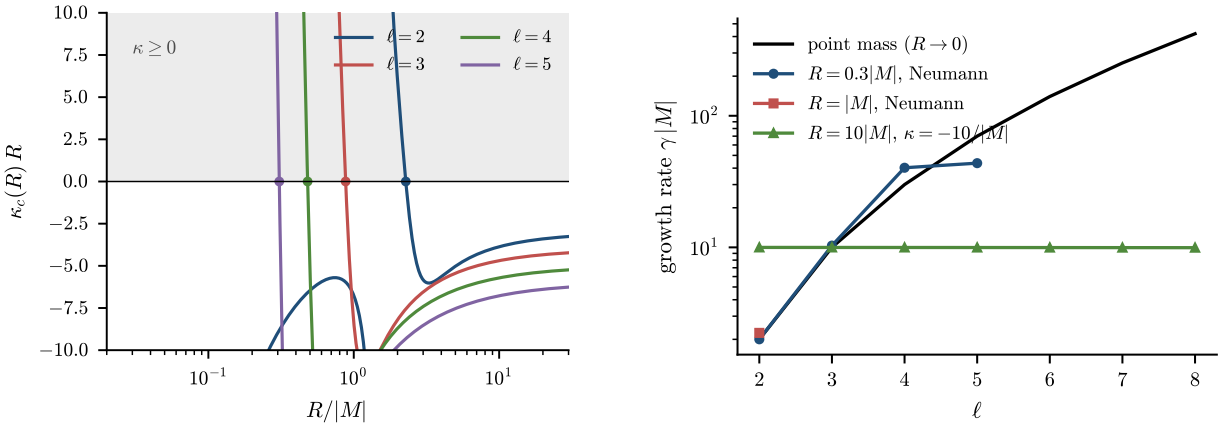


Figure 2: Left: critical surface condition $\kappa_c(R)R$ for $\ell = 2$–5. A mode is unstable when $\kappa < \kappa_c$, plus one unconditional mode when $R < r_s$ (pole). Dots mark r_*. Above r_* the whole $\kappa \geq 0$ region (shaded) is stable. Right: growth rate versus ℓ. The point mass grows as $\ell^4/12$; any finite R with an ℓ-independent condition leaves finitely many unstable ℓ ($\kappa \geq 0$) or caps the rate at $|\kappa|$ ($\kappa < 0$, since $\hat{V} \geq 0$ outside $r_{\rm neg}$).

Model. Following Ref. [3], take a complex scalar with $\mathcal{L} = -\frac{1}{2}|\nabla\Phi|^2 - V(|\Phi|^2)$, $V(s) = \frac{1}{2}s - \frac{1}{4}\lambda s^2 + \frac{1}{6}\mu s^3$, $\lambda = 10240$, $\lambda^2/\mu = 4.8$, coupled through

$$G_{ab} = 8\pi\varepsilon\, T_{ab}[\Phi], \qquad \Box\Phi = 2V'(|\Phi|^2)\Phi, \tag{9}$$

with $\varepsilon = +1$ (canonical) or $\varepsilon = -1$. For $\varepsilon = -1$ the field equation is unchanged but the star gravitates with negative ADM mass. In the language of Bondi, the scalar has a single mass parameter that is inertial, passive and active at once, and is negative for $\varepsilon = -1$; gravity alone cannot distinguish this from Bondi's "all three negative" [1, 2]. The action is that of a ghost, so the model is a classical probe; quantum mechanically it is unstable to vacuum decay [19].

Static stars. Stationary solutions $\Phi = \phi(r)e^{-i\omega t}$ in Schwarzschild-like coordinates are solved as two-point boundary-value problems with a decaying Yukawa tail. The configuration of Ref. [3] at $\omega = 0.7603$ has $M = -0.014580$, rms radius 4.40 and $|M|/R \approx 3 \times 10^{-3}$, far below the threshold $|M|/R < 0.439$ of Table 1: the shell where negative-mass Schwarzschild would be unstable lies deep inside the matter. (Our masses are ADM masses; those quoted in Ref. [3] are the mass enclosed where ϕ falls to 5% of its central value and are 1.5–2.3% smaller; the field profiles agree to 10^{-5}.)

First law. With $N = \int 4\pi r^2 \omega \phi^2 (a/\alpha)\,\mathrm{d}r$ the Noether charge, the family satisfies

$$\mathrm{d}M = \varepsilon\,\omega\,\mathrm{d}N, \tag{10}$$

verified by finite differences to $< 10^{-4}$. Hence $M(\omega)$ and $N(\omega)$ are extremal at the same ω for either sign, but $\mathrm{d}M/\mathrm{d}\omega$ and $\mathrm{d}N/\mathrm{d}\omega$ have opposite signs when $\varepsilon = -1$.

Radial perturbations. Perturbing the metric functions and both components of the field with $e^{i\sigma t}$, we eliminate the metric through the tr and rr constraints and obtain a closed fourth-order system for the real perturbation, a gauge-invariant phase and the perturbed enclosed charge, containing σ only as σ^2 and ε symbolically. Substituting back, all six linearised field equations are

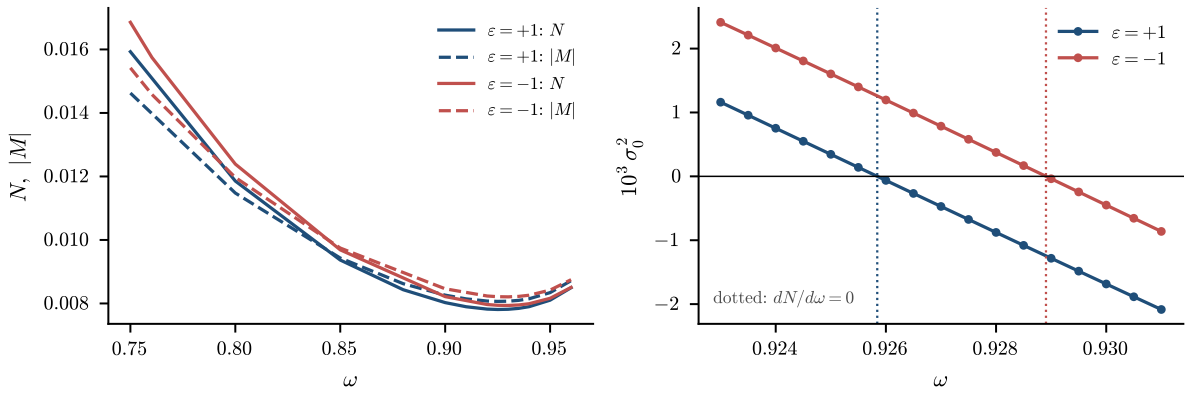


Figure 3: Radial stability of signed-source boson stars. Left: Noether charge N and $|M|$ along the canonical ($\varepsilon = +1$) and phantom ($\varepsilon = -1$) families. Right: fundamental σ_0^2 near the stability change; dotted lines mark $\mathrm{d}N/\mathrm{d}\omega = 0$, which coincides with $\sigma_0^2 = 0$ to 2×10^{-8} ($\varepsilon = +1$) and 8×10^{-8} ($\varepsilon = -1$) in ω.

satisfied identically. The structure is that of Refs. [20, 21]. Eigenvalues are found by compound-matrix shooting, which keeps the two-dimensional space of decaying solutions well conditioned, and are cross-checked by an independent finite-difference pencil that also returns complex eigenvalues.

Results. For $\varepsilon = +1$ the textbook criterion is reproduced at both turning points of the family: the fundamental mode crosses zero at $\omega = 0.92584444$ against $\mathrm{d}M/\mathrm{d}\omega = \mathrm{d}N/\mathrm{d}\omega = 0$ at 0.92584446, and again at the strong-field maximum of N ($\omega \approx 0.200$, $N \approx 42.73$) within the scan resolution. For $\varepsilon = -1$ (Fig. 3):

- The star of Ref. [3] is radially stable: no real growth rate up to $|\sigma| = 2$ and no complex eigenvalue with $|\sigma^2| < 0.3$, at two resolutions of the finite-difference check.
- The family is stable for $\omega < 0.92891$ and unstable above. The crossing $\sigma_0^2 = 0$ at $\omega = 0.92890846$ coincides with $\mathrm{d}N/\mathrm{d}\omega = 0$ at 0.92890838.
- The criterion is therefore invariant when stated in N (stable side $\mathrm{d}N/\mathrm{d}\omega < 0$) but reverses when stated in M: on the stable side $\mathrm{d}M/\mathrm{d}\omega = -\omega\,\mathrm{d}N/\mathrm{d}\omega > 0$.
- The phantom family has a fold in ω ($\omega_{\min} \approx 0.4223$) at which neither M nor N is extremal; the fundamental mode stays positive through it. The strong-field branch, followed to $|2m/r| \approx 0.4$, is stable with no turning point.

Near $\omega \approx 0.93$ the instability is essentially the flat-space Vakhitov–Kolokolov instability of Q-balls [22, 23], with gravity a small correction; the strong-field branch is the more sensitive test of how ε enters. The first law and the N-form of the criterion follow from the standard turning-point arguments [24–26] with ε kept; the new content is the explicit linear analysis for $\varepsilon = -1$. The result is consistent with the theorem that barotropic negative-mass stars are radially unstable [11], which does not apply to scalar-field matter.

Non-radial perturbations. For $\ell \geq 2$ we linearise in Regge–Wheeler gauge with ε symbolic. In the polar sector the traceless angular equation gives $H_2 = H_0$, and the (rr) equation must

be solved jointly with both Klein–Gordon equations; the result is a sixth-order system for $y = (H_1/s,\, K,\, F,\, F',\, G/s,\, G'/s)$, polynomial and even in s, generated by computer algebra. All eight separated field equations hold on its solutions to 7×10^{-7}; in vacuum it reduces exactly, through the Moncrief map, to the Zerilli equation plus a free scalar; and for $\varepsilon = +1$ it reproduces the fundamental $\ell = 2$ polar mode of a published mini boson star [27], $\sigma = 0.119519 - 5.35 \times 10^{-5} i$. The axial sector reduces to

$$Q_{,r_* r_*} = (s^2 + V_{\rm ax})Q, \qquad V_{\rm ax} = e^{\nu}\big[\ell(\ell+1)/r^2 - 6m/r^3 + 8\pi\varepsilon V(\phi_0^2)\big]. \tag{11}$$

Growing modes are sought with a matching determinant between the three regular interior solutions and the decaying exterior (Zerilli plus Yukawa) solutions, integrated with continuous orthonormalisation. For the phantom star the determinant has no real zero for $\gamma \in [10^{-3}, 300]$ ($\ell = 2$) and $[10^{-3}, 1000]$ ($\ell = 3$), ranges that contain the point-mass rates 137 and 686; the same holds for phantom stars at $\omega = 0.70$ and 0.85 and for the canonical star. An argument-principle count, validated on the known mode above, finds no zero with $0.1 \le \Re s \le 2$, $|\Im s| \le 2.5$, which also excludes oscillatory matter-sector instabilities in that region. The axial potential is positive for every $\ell \ge 2$ and every star examined, so the axial sector is stable.

The interior acts on the exterior through $\kappa_{\rm eff}(\ell, s)$, and the intertwiner gives the exact relation $\kappa_{\rm eff} - \kappa_c = s^2/(q_{\rm int} - g)$, with $q_{\rm int}$ the interior log-derivative and $g = \partial_x \ln \psi_0$. Hence $\kappa_{\rm eff} \to \kappa_c$ as $s \to 0$ for any star, with the sign fixed by a static tidal (Love-type) coefficient. For the phantom star, $\kappa_{\rm eff} > \kappa_c$ at every γ tabulated in $[10^{-4}, 150]$; it becomes positive at $\gamma \approx 2 \times 10^{-4}$ and then grows like $\gamma|M|$. By Theorem 2 the star never supplies the $\kappa < \kappa_c \approx -(\ell+1)/R$ an instability would need. These are scans, not proofs: a closely spaced pair of real roots, slowly growing modes with $\Re s < 0.1$, and $\ell \ge 4$ are not excluded.

Nonlinear check. We evolve single stars in spherical symmetry in polar-areal slicing, re-solving the Hamiltonian constraint for the Misner–Sharp mass [28] and the slicing condition at every substep, with ε appearing only there [29, 30]. The scheme is fourth order in space and time and converges at order ≈ 4; the Misner–Sharp mass outside the star equals the ADM mass of the static solution to 5×10^{-8}. Unstable stars at $\omega = 0.94$, perturbed by $\pm\delta$, grow at $\sigma = 0.07376$ ($\varepsilon = +1$) and 0.06679 ($\varepsilon = -1$) against 0.07370 and 0.06668 from the linear analysis (Fig. 4, right). The stable campaign stars of both signs remain stationary to $t = 1500$, with fractional drifts of ω, the central amplitude, the Misner–Sharp mass and N all $\le 10^{-6}$ at $h = 0.1$ and decreasing with resolution (Fig. 4, left). A 5% perturbation relaxes within ~ 150 time units onto the neighbouring static star and stays there. The slow drifts reported for a lone phantom star in 3+1 [3] are therefore not a property of the spherical dynamics.

6 Discussion

For the point mass, Theorem 1 completes the linear stability analysis of negative-mass Schwarzschild: one unstable even-parity mode per ℓ, at the Gleiser–Dotti rate, and no others. Theorem 2 shows where that mode lives. The negative part of the effective potential sits on a shell of radius $\approx 10|M|/\ell^2$ (Fig. 1); a star whose surface lies outside $r_*(\ell)$ hides it unless its interior supplies an energy-injecting surface condition, and for $\ell = 2$ the condition is $|M|/R < 0.439$. In this sense the instability is a point-mass effect, contrary to the suggestion in Ref. [8]: for a dilute regular source the vacuum exterior cannot drive it, and the ℓ^4 growth disappears.

What remains is a property of the matter. For the boson star of Ref. [3], which is dilute ($|M|/R \sim 10^{-3}$), we have shown radial stability and found no unstable $\ell = 2, 3$ polar or axial

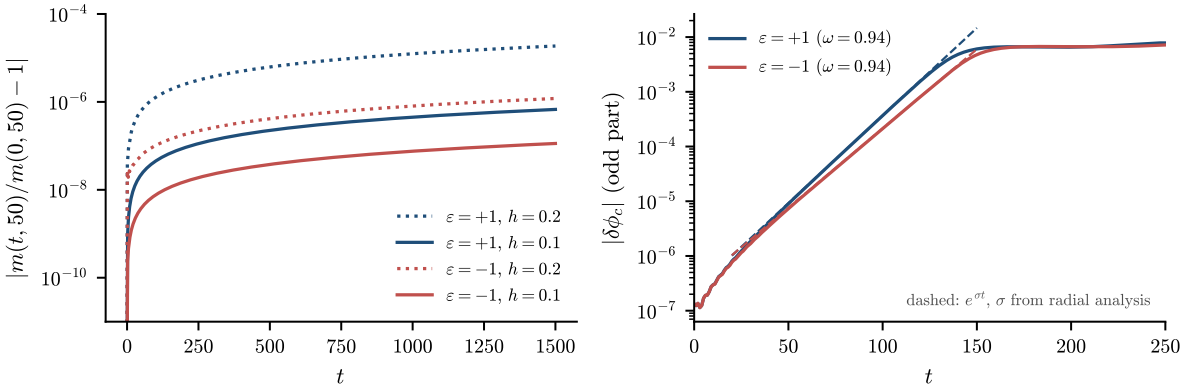


Figure 4: Spherically symmetric nonlinear evolutions. Left: relative drift of the Misner–Sharp mass at $r = 50$ for the stable campaign stars ($\omega = 0.750$ canonical, $\omega = 0.7603$ phantom) at two resolutions; the drift is a dissipation-limited truncation error that decreases rapidly with h. Right: odd part of the central-amplitude response of unstable stars ($\omega = 0.94$) to $\pm 10^{-5}$ perturbations; dashed lines have the growth rates of the linear analysis.

mode. Its interior supplies $\kappa_{\text{eff}} > \kappa_c$, so by Theorem 2 the vacuum instability is not triggered. Extending these scans to higher ℓ, to slowly growing modes, and to compact phantom stars, where $|M|/R$ approaches the thresholds of Table 1, is the natural next step.

Two limitations should be stated. Our results are classical: the phantom sector is a ghost, and a quantum theory of it has an unstable vacuum [19]. And the Robin model of the interior is exact only for an interface condition independent of frequency; a real star supplies a frequency-dependent one, for which Theorem 2 gives the count at each fixed frequency.

7 How the results were obtained

The author set the questions and scope and reviewed each stage; Anthropic's Claude, run as an agent with a Python environment and parallel sub-agents, did the literature reading, derivations, code and drafting. No claim rests on the assistant's word alone:

- *Gaps.* Starting from Bondi [1], each later paper was read for what it proves versus asserts; the open points became the phases of a written plan.
- *Starting points.* Published results were re-derived before use, exposing a sign misprint in Ref. [6] and the discontinuous mode of Ref. [4]; the stars of Ref. [3] were reproduced to 10^{-5}.
- *Proofs.* Every identity behind Lemma 1 and Theorems 1–2 was verified in exact arithmetic (SymPy), and the predicted mode counts were confirmed by a 1000-case spectral scan.
- *Numerics.* Each eigenvalue was computed by two independent methods; the evolution code was checked by convergence order, mass conservation and recovery of the linear growth rates.
- *Review.* Separate agents audited the codes without seeing our conclusions, and a literature search preceded every novelty claim (it found, e.g., that the post-Newtonian Bondi-pair law was already known [12]).

These checks are internal; the work has not yet been reviewed by specialists.

Reproducibility. The symbolic verifications (Lemma 1, Theorems 1–2, exact for $\ell = 2$–10 and symbolically in ℓ where stated; root isolation of $\mathcal{N}$ for $\ell \leq 50$), the spectral computations, the boson-star background and perturbation codes, the nonlinear evolution code, and the script that generates every figure are in the accompanying repository.

Acknowledgments. The author thanks Anthropic's Claude, which carried out the analysis, computations and drafting described in Sec. 7 under the author's direction.

References

[1] H. Bondi, "Negative mass in general relativity," Rev. Mod. Phys. **29**, 423 (1957).

[2] W. B. Bonnor, "Negative mass in general relativity," Gen. Relativ. Gravit. **21**, 1143 (1989).

[3] N. M. Shirokov, "The Bondi dipole in full numerical relativity: a self-accelerating positive–negative mass binary," arXiv:2608.24577.

[4] G. W. Gibbons, S. A. Hartnoll and A. Ishibashi, "On the stability of naked singularities," Prog. Theor. Phys. **113**, 963 (2005), arXiv:hep-th/0409307.

[5] R. J. Gleiser and G. Dotti, "Instability of the negative mass Schwarzschild naked singularity," Class. Quantum Grav. **23**, 5063 (2006), arXiv:gr-qc/0604021.

[6] G. Dotti and R. J. Gleiser, "The initial value problem for linearized gravitational perturbations of the Schwarzschild naked singularity," Class. Quantum Grav. **26**, 215002 (2009), arXiv:0809.3615.

[7] V. Cardoso and M. Cavaglià, "Stability of naked singularities and algebraically special modes," Phys. Rev. D **74**, 024027 (2006), arXiv:gr-qc/0604101.

[8] G. Dotti, "Linear stability of black holes and naked singularities," Universe **8**, 38 (2022), arXiv:2201.03640.

[9] S. Mbarek and M. B. Paranjape, "Negative mass bubbles in de Sitter space-time," Phys. Rev. D **90**, 101502 (2014), arXiv:1407.1457.

[10] M. C. Johnson, M. B. Paranjape, A. Savard and A. Tapia-Arellano, "Stable, thin wall, negative mass bubbles in de Sitter space-time," arXiv:1910.01774.

[11] M. de Aguiar Alves, A. G. S. Landulfo and B. Arderucio Costa, arXiv:2408.00154; Phys. Rev. D **111**, 044027 (2025).

[12] P. B. Ivanov, "On relativistic motion of a pair of particles having opposite signs of masses," Phys. Usp. **55**, 1232 (2012), arXiv:1204.1269.

[13] F. J. Zerilli, "Effective potential for even-parity Regge–Wheeler gravitational perturbation equations," Phys. Rev. Lett. **24**, 737 (1970); Phys. Rev. D **2**, 2141 (1970).

[14] A. Giveon, B. Kol, A. Ori and A. Sever, "On the resolution of the time-like singularities in Reissner–Nordström and negative-mass Schwarzschild," JHEP **08**, 014 (2004), arXiv:hep-th/0401209.

[15] M. Reed and B. Simon, *Methods of Modern Mathematical Physics II: Fourier Analysis, Self-Adjointness* (Academic Press, 1975).

[16] J. Weidmann, *Spectral Theory of Ordinary Differential Operators*, Lecture Notes in Mathematics 1258 (Springer, 1987).

[17] M. Sh. Birman and M. Z. Solomyak, *Spectral Theory of Self-Adjoint Operators in Hilbert Space* (Reidel, 1987).

[18] F. Gesztesy, B. Simon and G. Teschl, "Zeros of the Wronskian and renormalized oscillation theory," Amer. J. Math. **118**, 571 (1996).

[19] J. M. Cline, S. Jeon and G. D. Moore, "The phantom menaced: constraints on low-energy effective ghosts," Phys. Rev. D **70**, 043543 (2004), arXiv:hep-ph/0311312.

[20] M. Gleiser and R. Watkins, "Gravitational stability of scalar matter," Nucl. Phys. B **319**, 733 (1989).

[21] B. Kain, "Radial oscillations and stability of multiple-field boson stars," Phys. Rev. D **103**, 123003 (2021).

[22] S. Coleman, "Q-balls," Nucl. Phys. B **262**, 263 (1985).

[23] R. Friedberg, T. D. Lee and Y. Pang, "Mini-soliton stars," Phys. Rev. D **35**, 3640 (1987).

[24] R. D. Sorkin, "A stability criterion for many-parameter equilibrium families," Astrophys. J. **257**, 847 (1982).

[25] T. D. Lee and Y. Pang, "Stability of mini-boson stars," Nucl. Phys. B **315**, 477 (1989).

[26] F. V. Kusmartsev, E. W. Mielke and F. E. Schunck, "Gravitational stability of boson stars," Phys. Rev. D **43**, 3895 (1991).

[27] C. F. B. Macedo, P. Pani, V. Cardoso and L. C. B. Crispino, "Astrophysical signatures of boson stars: quasinormal modes and inspiral resonances," Phys. Rev. D **88**, 064046 (2013), arXiv:1307.4812.

[28] C. W. Misner and D. H. Sharp, "Relativistic equations for adiabatic, spherically symmetric gravitational collapse," Phys. Rev. **136**, B571 (1964).

[29] E. Seidel and W.-M. Suen, "Dynamical evolution of boson stars: perturbing the ground state," Phys. Rev. D **42**, 384 (1990).

[30] S. H. Hawley and M. W. Choptuik, "Boson stars driven to the brink of black hole formation," Phys. Rev. D **62**, 104024 (2000).